ASSOCIATION FOR FINANCIAL PROFESSIONALS

DATAWISE ACADEMY

BoardReady Review

Sample draft — October close flash and Q4 forecast memo

Critique, consistency review and enrichment suggestions by Elena Varga, the Group Controller and the Red-Team Reviewer

Think · Ask · Data Wise Academy

10 November 2026

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Review Brief

What was reviewed, by whom, and each verdict

The Markdown file **sample-draft-forecast-memo.md** (263 words) was reviewed by 3 personas from the Think_Ask kit, for 9 reviews in all. A chair then combined them.

Each reviewer's verdict

Reviewer	Request	Verdict
Elena Varga	Criticize	No, I would not take this to the board today, because the headline, the cash figure and the hiring recommendation all rest on numbers I cannot tie to anything.
Elena Varga	Review for consistency	No. The memo contradicts itself on scope, late files and rate basis, so I cannot tell what the $48.6M contains.
Elena Varga	Suggest enrichments	I would not take this to the board today; it has no reconciliation, no constant-currency view, and a spending recommendation resting on one unexplained month.
The Group Controller	Criticize	No, this cannot go to the CFO today, because none of the figures names a source, a rate, a date or a method, and at least three claims point to possible double-counting or mixed-date data.
The Group Controller	Review for consistency	No, this memo cannot go to the CFO today: several statements contradict each other or are unsupported by anything in the document, and at least one total is likely overstated.
The Group Controller	Suggest enrichments	The memo cannot go to the CFO today without a restatement risk, because the revenue, consolidation, cash and EBITDA figures have no stated source, method or reconciliation.
The Red-Team Reviewer	Criticize	No, this would not survive a first challenge from either side. The headline number, the coverage statement and the cash figure each contain a sentence that lets someone dispute them or quote them back.
The Red-Team Reviewer	Review for consistency	No, it would not survive a first challenge: the memo contradicts itself on coverage, on what "cash" and "revenue" mean, and its recommendation rests on a headline it never substantiates.
The Red-Team Reviewer	Suggest enrichments	As written, this memo would not survive a regional GM's first question ("up 12% against which budget, and is my region in it?") or an auditor's first reconciliation, and it needs the additions below before it can go to the board.

> The personas critique; they never rewrite. The author stays responsible for every number.

Panel Synthesis

The chair combines the reviews

Verdict: Not yet ready for its reader: all three reviewers agree the $48.6M headline cannot be tied out, and the cash figure and hiring recommendation rest on it.

The three points most likely to stop it

1. **Possible double counting in the headline.** "Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included, to give the board the fullest picture of activity." Raised by Elena Varga, the Group Controller and the Red-Team Reviewer, all of whom make it their first fix. Regions and BUs usually cut the same revenue two ways, so $48.6M and "up 12%" may be overstated. Fix: confirm whether the two were summed, show the eliminations, and provide a bridge from the 100 files to $48.6M. The Red-Team adds that the word "fullest" will be read aloud.
2. **Unstated treatment of late files and FX.** "Late files were handled as usual." "Converted at the month-end rate." Raised by all three. "All 100 consolidated" sits badly with late files, and it is not stated whether they were estimated, carried forward or excluded. Month-end rates for revenue, against a budget at an unstated rate, may put FX inside the 12%. Fix: a late-file schedule with the dollar effect, the rates used and a constant-currency or budget-rate view.
3. **Cash and the hiring recommendation without support.** "Group cash stands at $42.0M… latest statements received from each bank. This is a comfortable position." "Given the strong October, we recommend lifting the Q4 hiring freeze." Raised by all three. Statement dates differ and there is no reconciliation, restricted-cash split or covenant test. "Comfortable" has no benchmark. One month does not show a recovery. Elena Varga asks for a downside case. Fix: cash by bank with date, reconciliation and covenant headroom. Add a hiring cost with a low case, an owner and a decision date.

Also raised: "improved to 14.2%" has no comparator or list of one-offs. The $152M implies about $103.4M for November–December, with "recent experience" unquantified. Elena Varga and the Controller flag this arithmetic.

Where the panel disagrees

The panel does not really disagree; it differs on emphasis. The Red-Team Reviewer frames the risks as disputes, such as a GM rejecting an estimated file or a quoted sentence.

Panel Synthesis

The chair combines the reviews (continued)

Elena Varga and the Controller frame them as audit and restatement risks. The author must decide whether to fix the number first, as all agree, or also rewrite the disputable phrasing. The Red-Team Reviewer also asks for regional evidence for Europe and Latin America.

What to add first

1. A bridge from the 100 files to the consolidated $48.6M, showing regional/BU eliminations and late-file treatment (Controller, Red-Team; Elena Varga ranks a revenue bridge at budget rates first).
2. A revenue bridge at budget rates, splitting the 12% into FX, scope, timing and underlying volume.
3. Cash by bank with statement dates, a ledger reconciliation, restrictions and covenant headroom.

The business question, sharpened

Is October revenue of $48.6M, free of double counting and measured at budget rates, strong enough, with cash and covenant headroom confirmed, to justify lifting the Q4 hiring freeze in Europe and Latin America?

Elena Varga

The Skeptical CFO · the one who signs and presents to the board.

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Critique

Elena Varga · Group CFO

> No, I would not take this to the board today, because the headline, the cash figure and the hiring recommendation all rest on numbers I cannot tie to anything.

Objection 1: Double counting and an unreconciled headline

"Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included, to give the board the fullest picture of activity."

Those are two cuts of the same revenue. Adding them overstates the group. I would need to check whether the $48.6M contains both. If it does, the "up 12% against budget" is mechanical, not performance.

The same sentence has other problems:

- "Local-currency results were converted at the month-end rate." Budget is set at budget rates. Comparing actuals at spot to budget at budget rates mixes FX into the variance. I see no constant-currency view.
- "Late files were handled as usual." I do not know what that means. Were they estimated? Carried forward? Left out? Out of 100 files, that is a material gap.
- Nothing ties to the ledger or to September.

Will this number survive the audit committee? No.

Objection 2: Cash is not a position, it is a stack of statements

"Group cash stands at $42.0M across our three banks, based on the latest statements received from each bank. This is a comfortable position."

"Latest received" means different dates for different banks. No cut-off date is given. There is no reconciliation to the ledger, no outstanding items, no split between trapped, restricted and free cash. The memo says "three banks", but the consolidation covers files from banks and regions. I would need to check whether that is the full list.

"Comfortable" against what? No covenant is mentioned. I will not call cash comfortable without the covenant headroom.

Critique

Elena Varga · Group CFO (continued)

Objection 3: The recommendation does not survive the worst reading

"Given the strong October, we recommend lifting the Q4 hiring freeze in Europe and Latin America."

This commits money on the back of a month I cannot trust (see Objection 1). One month is not a trend, and "the recovery is well under way" is a story, not evidence.

The forecast gives no support either:

- "We forecast Q4 revenue of $152M, assuming pipeline conversion in line with recent experience." Which experience, what rate, and what range? October is $48.6M. The $152M implies roughly $103M for November and December combined. I would need to see how that was built.
- "Adjusted EBITDA margin improved to 14.2%, excluding one-off items." Improved from what? Which items were excluded, and how much are they? I see no reconciliation to reported EBITDA.

What decision does this change? It lifts a freeze. It needs a downside case, and there is none.

Smaller points

- "Finance will tighten the close process" has no owner or date.
- "This memo will be updated as needed" tells me the numbers will move after I present them.

Question for the FP&A lead

Show me one bridge: October revenue from ledger to $48.6M, with no double counting, estimated late files marked, and budget compared at budget rates. Can you produce it before I see anything else?

Consistency review

Elena Varga · Group CFO

> No. The memo contradicts itself on scope, late files and rate basis, so I cannot tell what the $48.6M contains.

Inconsistencies

#	First statement	Conflicting statement	The inconsistency	Why it matters to you
1	"All 100 monthly files from business units, banks and regions were consolidated."	"Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included, to give the board the fullest picture of activity."	Regional and BU totals usually cut the same revenue two ways. Including both suggests double counting. I would need to check.	"$48.6M" and "up 12%" may be overstated.
2	"All 100 monthly files… were consolidated. Late files were handled as usual."	"Finance will tighten the close process to avoid late files in future."	Late files existed, yet "all 100" are said to be in. "As usual" sits badly with a control fix. How they were handled is not stated.	Estimates may sit inside the actuals. The number can move after the board.
3	"Local-currency results were converted at the month-end rate."	"up 12% against budget"	The budget rate basis is not stated. The 12% may be partly FX, not performance.	The variance may be mechanical.
4	"Group revenue reached $48.6M in October"	"We forecast Q4 revenue of $152M, assuming pipeline conversion in line with recent experience."	$152M less $48.6M leaves $103.4M for two months. That is about $51.7M a month, above October. "Recent experience" gives no figure. I would need to check whether $152M includes October actuals.	The forecast needs growth the text does not explain.
5	"Group cash stands at $42.0M across our three banks, based on the latest statements received from each bank."	"100 monthly files from business units, banks and regions"	"Latest statements" means no common date. The conversion rate for cash is not stated.	Cash is not a month-end position. "Comfortable" has no covenant or debt reference.
6	"up 12% against budget, confirming that the recovery is well under way."	"Given the strong October, we recommend lifting the Q4 hiring freeze in Europe and Latin America."	Budget beat is read as recovery, which needs a prior-period comparison. One month, with the scope doubts in rows 1–3, is used to justify spending. No Europe or LatAm figures are given.	The decision rests on a number that has not tied.
7	"Adjusted EBITDA margin improved to 14.2%, excluding one-off items."	(No comparative anywhere in the memo.)	"Improved" from what? The one-off items are not listed.	I cannot defend an adjusted figure with no bridge.
8	"Draft 0.3… ahead of the 18 November board meeting"	"This memo will be updated as needed."	The numbers are presented as closed but are open-ended. No cut-off or owner is given.	A figure that moves after the board damages my credibility.

Fix first

Row 1. Establish whether regional and BU totals were both added into $48.6M.

Consistency review

Elena Varga · Group CFO (continued)

Every other figure, the 12% variance, the forecast and the hiring recommendation, depends on that scope.

Enrichment suggestions

Elena Varga · Group CFO

> I would not take this to the board today; it has no reconciliation, no constant-currency view, and a spending recommendation resting on one unexplained month.

Suggested additions

1. **A revenue bridge at budget rates, tied to the ledger.** Goes in section 1, after "up 12% against budget". Split the 12% into FX translation, scope changes (acquisitions, disposals), timing and underlying volume/price. Why: I cannot tell if the variance is performance or mechanical. Data: budget rates, October actual rates, entity-level revenue in local currency, and the consolidated trial balance.
2. **Rate policy and FX disclosure.** Goes at "Local-currency results were converted at the month-end rate". Revenue is a flow and is normally translated at average rate. Show October on both bases, name the rates used, and state the policy. Data: treasury rate table, group accounting policy.
3. **A consolidation completeness and eliminations schedule.** Goes in sections 2 and 3: "Late files were handled as usual" and "Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included". Show files received versus expected, which were late, how each was estimated, and the dollar effect. Confirm regional and BU views are not summed, and show intercompany eliminations. Why: this reads as possible double counting, and "as usual" will not survive the audit committee. Data: file tracker, late-file estimates, the consolidation mapping, intercompany ledger.
4. **Cash by bank, by statement date, with restrictions.** Goes at "Group cash stands at $42.0M across our three banks". Show each balance, the statement date, FX applied, and a reconciliation to the general ledger. Separate trapped, pledged or restricted cash, and add covenant headroom. Why: "latest statements received" means mixed dates, and "comfortable" is an adjective, not a test. Data: bank statements, GL cash accounts, facility agreements, covenant calculations.
5. **Definition and reconciliation of adjusted EBITDA.** Goes at "improved to 14.2%, excluding one-off items". List each one-off, its amount and its precedent. Show reported EBITDA beside adjusted, and the prior-month and budget margins. Data: the add-back schedule with approvals, and prior-period comparatives.

Enrichment suggestions

Elena Varga · Group CFO (continued)

1. **Forecast build and downside case, linked to the hiring decision.** Goes at "$152M, assuming pipeline conversion in line with recent experience" and in section 7. Quantify the conversion rates, show the October-implied run rate, and add a low case. State the cost of lifting the freeze (headcount, annualised) and show it holds under the low case and against covenants. Name an owner and a decision date. Data: CRM pipeline by stage, historical conversion, the hiring plan, the cost model.

The one addition that matters most

The revenue bridge at budget rates (item 1), tied to the ledger. Without it I cannot say whether October was real, and the hiring recommendation depends on that.

The Group Controller

The Controller · the one who checks that every number ties.

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Critique

The Group Controller

> No, this cannot go to the CFO today, because none of the figures names a source, a rate, a date or a method, and at least three claims point to possible double-counting or mixed-date data.

Figure and claim check

Figure or claim (quoted)	Status	What the author must add
"$48.6M in October"	Untied	Consolidation file or trial balance reference. Whether it includes both regional and BU totals (see row 4).
"up 12% against budget"	Untied	Budget version and date, budget amount in $, and the basis (same FX rate as actuals or budget rate).
"converted at the month-end rate"	Unverifiable	Rate per currency, source of rate, date. Whether the P&L was translated at month-end rather than average rate, and why.
"All 100 monthly files... were consolidated"	Untied	File list by entity, with the count received, the count consolidated, and the count of entities expected.
"Late files were handled as usual"	Unverifiable	Which files were late, and whether each was replaced by an estimate, a carry-forward or the prior month. Revenue effect in $.
"Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included"	Untied	Evidence of elimination. Regions and BUs are normally two cuts of the same revenue. If both were summed, $48.6M is overstated.
"Adjusted EBITDA margin improved to 14.2%"	Untied	Prior-period margin for the comparison, EBITDA and revenue amounts, and the same basis for both periods.
"excluding one-off items"	Unverifiable	List of each item excluded, amount and rationale. Whether the same policy was applied to the comparative period.
"Q4 revenue of $152M"	Untied	Model file, split of October actual and Nov–Dec forecast, FX rate assumption. $152M less $48.6M implies about $103.4M for two months, which is above October's run rate. The memo gives no bridge.
"pipeline conversion in line with recent experience"	Unverifiable	Conversion rate, the period used for "recent", and the pipeline value.
"$42.0M across our three banks"	Untied	Bank-by-bank balances, statement dates, currencies and rates, and a reconciliation to the ledger.
"latest statements received from each bank"	Unverifiable	Statement date for each bank. Different dates mean the total is not a single point in time and is not a month-end figure.
"This is a comfortable position"	Unverifiable	Comparison basis: minimum cash, covenant or forecast outflows.
"Given the strong October"	Untied	This depends on the $48.6M and the 12%, which are untied. The recommendation inherits that exposure.

Critique

The Group Controller (continued)

Number that would do the most damage

$48.6M October revenue. The memo states that regional and business-unit totals were both included, which suggests double-counting. It also includes late files with an unstated treatment and uses an unspecified FX rate. The 12% variance, the Q4 forecast and the hiring recommendation all depend on it. If it is restated after the board sees it, the other figures lose credibility with it.

Consistency review

The Group Controller

> No, this memo cannot go to the CFO today: several statements contradict each other or are unsupported by anything in the document, and at least one total is likely overstated.

Inconsistencies

#	First statement (quoted)	Conflicting statement (quoted)	The inconsistency	Why it matters to you
1	"Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included"	"Group revenue reached $48.6M in October"	Regions and business units usually cut the same revenue two ways. Including both suggests double counting. I would need to check the files.	The $48.6M and the +12% may both be overstated and later restated.
2	"All 100 monthly files from business units, banks and regions were consolidated"	"Late files were handled as usual"	"All" were consolidated, yet late files exist. It is not stated whether they were actuals, estimates or carry-forwards.	Actuals and estimates are mixed in one headline figure.
3	"Group cash stands at $42.0M across our three banks"	"based on the latest statements received from each bank"	The cash date is not stated, and the statement dates may differ by bank. The memo reports revenue at month-end, but cash may be earlier.	Cash may not be at the same cut-off as the October figures.
4	"Group cash stands at $42.0M across our three banks"	"All 100 monthly files from business units, banks and regions"	The memo refers to three banks, but the bank files are not listed or counted. The currency of the cash is not stated (see #6).	The cash figure cannot be tied to the files.
5	"Group revenue reached $48.6M in October, up 12% against budget"	"confirming that the recovery is well under way"	A single month against budget does not show a recovery, which implies a trend over time. No prior period is given.	The conclusion goes beyond the figures.
6	"Local-currency results were converted at the month-end rate"	"Group revenue reached $48.6M"	Rates, currencies and rate source are not given. Month-end rate applied to P&L conflicts with usual average-rate practice, and the budget rate basis is not stated.	The +12% may be partly FX, not performance.
7	"Adjusted EBITDA margin improved to 14.2%, excluding one-off items"	"Group revenue reached $48.6M in October"	"Improved" has no comparison base. One-offs are not listed, and the period (October or year to date) is not stated.	The margin cannot be traced or compared.
8	"We forecast Q4 revenue of $152M"	"Group revenue reached $48.6M in October"	$152M for the quarter implies about $103.4M for November and December combined, or about $51.7M a month. That is above October's pace, and the memo does not say whether the $152M includes October actuals.	The forecast depends on an unstated step-up and on an undefined "recent experience".
9	"Given the strong October, we recommend lifting the Q4 hiring freeze"	"Finance will tighten the close process to avoid late files in future"	The recommendation rests on October figures that the memo itself says were affected by late files.	A decision is based on numbers whose quality the memo concedes is weak.

Consistency review

The Group Controller (continued)

#	First statement (quoted)	Conflicting statement (quoted)	The inconsistency	Why it matters to you
10	"ahead of the 18 November board meeting"	"This memo will be updated as needed"	A draft 0.3 with open updates conflicts with a fixed board date. There is no cut-off for the update.	The board could see figures that are later changed.

Fix first

Resolve #1: confirm whether regional and business-unit totals overlap. If they do, the $48.6M, the +12%, the margin, the forecast base and the hiring recommendation all change at once.

Enrichment suggestions

The Group Controller

> The memo cannot go to the CFO today without a restatement risk, because the revenue, consolidation, cash and EBITDA figures have no stated source, method or reconciliation.

Suggested additions

1. **Consolidation scope and elimination schedule.** Goes in section 3: "Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included, to give the board the fullest picture of activity." Including both views risks double counting the same revenue. Why it matters: $48.6M may be overstated by the overlap, and intercompany sales are not mentioned either. Data needed: the entity list showing which files are regional and which are BU, the mapping between them, intercompany elimination entries, and a bridge from the sum of files to the consolidated $48.6M.
2. **File inventory with status and cut-off.** Goes in section 2: "All 100 monthly files... Late files were handled as usual." Why it matters: "as usual" hides a choice (estimate, carry-forward or exclusion). Data needed: a list of the files received, their dates, the number late, what was substituted for each late file, the amount of revenue and cash that rests on estimates, and the cut-off date for submissions.
3. **FX translation note.** Goes in section 1: "Local-currency results were converted at the month-end rate." Why it matters: P&L items are normally translated at the average rate, so the stated method may be wrong, and the budget comparison needs the same rate basis. Data needed: the rate table by currency with source and date, the budget rate used, and the revenue split by currency, plus the variance split between volume and FX.
4. **Budget baseline and variance bridge.** Goes in section 1: "up 12% against budget". Why it matters: the budget version, the budget amount and the base used for the percentage are not stated. Data needed: the approved budget file and version, the October budget in dollars, the prior-year October and September comparatives, and the actual-vs-budget variance by BU.

Enrichment suggestions

The Group Controller (continued)

1. **EBITDA reconciliation and one-off list.** Goes in section 4: "Adjusted EBITDA margin improved to 14.2%, excluding one-off items." Why it matters: "improved" needs a comparator, and the adjustments are not itemised. Data needed: reported EBITDA, each adjustment with amount and approval, the prior-period margin on the same definition, and the numerator and denominator behind 14.2%.
2. **Cash by bank with statement dates.** Goes in section 6: "Group cash stands at $42.0M across our three banks, based on the latest statements received from each bank." Why it matters: statements of different dates are not a single period-end balance. Data needed: the balance per bank, the statement date, the currency and rate used, any unreconciled items, in-transit items, and restricted or trapped cash. Also state how "three banks" squares with files from "banks" in section 2.

Also needed for the Q4 forecast in section 5 ("$152M, assuming pipeline conversion in line with recent experience"): the conversion rate, the period it is drawn from, the pipeline file, and the implied November and December revenue after October actuals.

The one addition that matters most

The bridge from the 100 files to the consolidated $48.6M, showing eliminations of the regional/BU overlap and the treatment of late files. Every other figure in the memo, including the 12%, the 14.2% and the $152M forecast, depends on this number being right.

The Red-Team Reviewer

The Red-Team Reviewer · the one who attacks from outside finance.

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Critique

The Red-Team Reviewer

> No, this would not survive a first challenge from either side. The headline number, the coverage statement and the cash figure each contain a sentence that lets someone dispute them or quote them back.

Attack 1: Double counting, and nobody can prove it

Scenario (auditor): A restatement shows October revenue included both regional rollups and the business units they roll up. The chair asks why the memo disclosed the overlap and did nothing about it.

Quote: "Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included, to give the board the fullest picture of activity." Together with "Group revenue reached $48.6M in October, up 12% against budget."

Why it matters: Summing regions and BUs counts the same revenue twice, or at least cuts the same revenue two ways. The memo says this was deliberate and presents it as a virtue. The 12% is then either inflated or not comparable to a budget built on one cut. I can't tell which, and neither can the board. The word "fullest" will be read aloud.

Attack 2: "Late files were handled as usual" gives a GM a free exit

Scenario (business): A regional GM's file arrived late. Their number was estimated, carried forward, or left out. They see the variance, say "that's not my actual," and refuse the miss. If actuals later come in higher, they claim the upside. If lower, they say the number was never theirs.

Quote: "All 100 monthly files... were consolidated. Late files were handled as usual."

Why it matters: "All 100 consolidated" and "late files handled" don't fit together. The memo doesn't say how many were late, what "handled" meant (estimate, prior month, exclusion) or which entities were affected. Add "Local-currency results were converted at the month-end rate" and a second dispute opens. Budget rate or average rate? A GM in a weakening-currency region will say the variance is FX, not performance. The memo gives no constant-currency view to rebut that.

Critique

The Red-Team Reviewer (continued)

Attack 3: Cash of $42.0M with mixed dates, labeled "comfortable"

Scenario (auditor): A bank balance turns out to be weeks stale, or a restricted or trapped balance sits in the total. Cash was then lower than $42.0M at the reporting date, and hiring was lifted partly on it.

Quote: "Group cash stands at $42.0M across our three banks, based on the latest statements received from each bank. This is a comfortable position."

Why it matters: "Latest statements received" means different as-of dates per bank, and none is stated. Nothing covers restricted cash, intercompany balances or in-transit items. Also, the intro mentions banks as sources among the 100 files, yet only three banks are named, so completeness is unproven. "Comfortable" has no threshold behind it. This is the sentence that gets quoted.

Lesser, but live

- "Adjusted EBITDA margin improved to 14.2%, excluding one-off items." No definition of what was excluded, no prior comparison, and the GM's bonus metric could hinge on that list.
- The hiring recommendation rests on "the strong October," which depends on the unresolved revenue figure. It names Europe and Latin America without regional evidence.
- "Finance will tighten the close process" concedes a control failure with no owner or date.

The sentence the chair reads aloud

"Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included, to give the board the fullest picture of activity."

Consistency review

The Red-Team Reviewer

> No, it would not survive a first challenge: the memo contradicts itself on coverage, on what "cash" and "revenue" mean, and its recommendation rests on a headline it never substantiates.

Inconsistencies

#	First statement (quoted)	Conflicting statement (quoted)	The inconsistency	Why it matters to you
1	"Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included"	"Group revenue reached $48.6M in October"	Regions and BUs usually cut the same revenue two ways. Including both risks double counting, and the memo never says it eliminated the overlap. I would need to check.	If $48.6M is inflated, "up 12%" is inflated, and my bonus baseline moves.
2	"up 12% against budget"	"confirming that the recovery is well under way"	Variance against budget is not a recovery trend. No prior-period or year-on-year figure is given.	"Recovery" is claimed, but the memo supports only a budget beat.
3	"Group revenue reached $48.6M in October"	"We forecast Q4 revenue of $152M"	The Q4 forecast is $152M and October is $48.6M. The memo does not say how much Nov-Dec is implied or whether the forecast includes October actuals. The implied run-rate is not stated.	I can't tell what Nov-Dec target I'm being held to.
4	"All 100 monthly files from business units, banks and regions were consolidated."	"Late files were handled as usual." / "avoid late files in future"	"All" were consolidated, yet files were late. "Handled as usual" is undefined: estimated, excluded, or carried forward?	If my file was late and estimated, I'll dispute the number.
5	"Group cash stands at $42.0M across our three banks"	"100 monthly files from business units, banks and regions"	Cash is stated for three banks, but the consolidation includes more bank files, and the count is not reconciled. I would need to check.	A cash figure with an unclear scope is not reliable.
6	"based on the latest statements received from each bank"	"Local-currency results were converted at the month-end rate."	Bank statements may carry different dates, and conversion for cash is not specified. The cash date is not a single date.	Cash is not a consistent point-in-time figure, yet it is called "comfortable".
7	"Adjusted EBITDA margin improved to 14.2%, excluding one-off items."	"up 12% against budget"	Revenue is unadjusted, while EBITDA is adjusted, with no definition, no list of one-offs, no prior margin. "Improved" has no baseline.	One-offs could be shifted between my region and the group to flatter the margin.
8	"Given the strong October"	"We forecast Q4 revenue of $152M, assuming pipeline conversion in line with recent experience."	The recommendation relies on one month, and the forecast relies on an undefined "recent experience".	Lifting a hiring freeze is a cost commitment resting on vague support.

Consistency review

The Red-Team Reviewer (continued)

#	First statement (quoted)	Conflicting statement (quoted)	The inconsistency	Why it matters to you
9	"lifting the Q4 hiring freeze in Europe and Latin America"	"Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included"	No regional figures are shown for Europe or Latin America, so the recommendation is not tied to those regions' results.	Why those two regions and not the others? That's contestable.
10	"Finance will tighten the close process"	"This memo will be updated as needed."	No owner, date or trigger. Draft 0.3 for a board meeting leaves it open whether figures are final.	After a restatement, "as needed" will be quoted back at the CFO.

Fix first

Row 1: state whether regional and business-unit totals overlap and how the overlap was eliminated. Every other figure (growth, margin, forecast, hiring recommendation) depends on $48.6M being right.

Enrichment suggestions

The Red-Team Reviewer

> As written, this memo would not survive a regional GM's first question ("up 12% against which budget, and is my region in it?") or an auditor's first reconciliation, and it needs the additions below before it can go to the board.

Suggested additions

1. **A double-count reconciliation of regions versus business units.** Goes in section 3: "Regional totals and business-unit totals were both included, to give the board the fullest picture of activity." If both are summed, $48.6M is overstated, and every GM will claim the other cut is the one that counts. Add the consolidation logic: which cut is the basis for the group figure, the other cut as memo-only, and a bridge between them. Data: the mapping of BUs to regions, and the intercompany and elimination schedule.
2. **A revenue bridge: budget, actual, FX, and a like-for-like basis.** Goes in section 1: "up 12% against budget, confirming that the recovery is well under way." Show the budget figure in dollars, and the variance split into volume, price, FX and any acquisitions or timing. "Recovery" implies a prior-period comparison, so add prior-month and prior-year too. Data: the approved budget version and date, and the prior-year October actuals.
3. **FX disclosure and a constant-currency view.** Goes in section 1: "converted at the month-end rate." Say which rates (with source and date), whether the budget used a different rate, and show the variance at budget rates. Otherwise my local-currency results get blamed on a rate I do not control. Data: month-end and budget rates by currency, plus the local-currency results.
4. **A late-file schedule and the estimation method.** Goes in section 2: "Late files were handled as usual." List which files were late, their size, whether they were estimated, and the estimate's basis. State the total of all 100 files received versus estimated. Data: the file tracker with receipt dates and the estimation workings.

Enrichment suggestions

The Red-Team Reviewer (continued)

1. **An adjusted EBITDA definition and a reconciliation to reported.** Goes in section 4: "excluding one-off items." List each exclusion with amount, the approver, and comparability with the budget and prior-year margins. Without it, the margin cannot be defended and my region's costs may be sitting in "one-offs". Data: the general ledger and adjustment log, and the policy on adjustments.
2. **Forecast assumptions, range, and cash basis.** Add to sections 5 and 6: the actual conversion rate used for "recent experience", a downside and upside case, and the pipeline by region. For cash, state the statement date per bank, the in-transit items, the restricted or trapped balances and the currency, since "latest statements received" mixes dates. Tie the hiring recommendation in section 7 to named thresholds and an owner. Data: the CRM pipeline history, the bank statements with dates, and the treasury cash position.

The one addition that matters most

The regions-versus-business-units reconciliation (item 1). If the $48.6M headline includes both cuts, everything built on it (the 12%, the margin, the forecast and the hiring decision) is wrong and open to dispute.

About This Review

How it was produced

- **Document:** sample-draft-forecast-memo.md (Markdown)
- **Personas:** `02-persona-skeptical-cfo.md`, `03-persona-controller.md`, `04-persona-red-team-reviewer.md`, from the Think_Ask folder
- **Requests:** Criticize, Review for consistency, Suggest enrichments
- **Model:** claude-sonnet-5-5 (anthropic)
- **Date:** 10 November 2026, 05:41

> **Read it as a pre-mortem, not a verdict**

The personas are fictional. Each one has a stated blind spot, and a model can misread a figure. Where two reviewers disagree, check the source yourself: that is the same reflex as tying a number to a second source.

Styled with `page_afp.css`, on the layout of `AFP2026_Doc_template.md`.